from Jamalpur and Bangladeshi elements that guided them towards Dacca. These were the lead elements of the Indian Army in the race to Dacca.

E3: Infantryman, eastern sector

This soldier serving in XXXIII Corps (**3a**) is armed with the 7.62mm 1A1 battle rifle. He wears a Mk III helmet with the standard olive-green uniform and Pattern 1937 web equipment. The Bangladesh War of 1971 was a race against time for the Indian Army as it tried to capture as much territory as possible in East Pakistan, before international pressure could be brought to bear on India to halt its military operations. The Eastern Command launched a multi-pronged offensive with three corps and 101 Communication Zone advancing on multiple thrust lines. The difficult terrain criss-crossed by numerous rivers made the offensive difficult during the 13 days of relentless operations.

F: 1971 (2)

F1: Radio operator, eastern sector

This radio operator of 9 Infantry Division (**1a**) is using an AN/PRC-25 radio set, carried on his back in its harness. He is armed with a Sterling SMG. The Indian Army's Corps of Signals played an important role as the Indian formations progressed their operations deeper inside East Pakistan and they strove to ensure seamless communications between the lead elements and the headquarters. One of the most challenging tasks was carried out by IV Corps signallers as they established communications for the corps headquarters at Comilla within enemy firing range.

F2: Mortar crewman, Border Security Force

This crewman is handling a 3in mortar round. He wears the Mk III helmet with the olive-green uniform and standard web equipment. The 3in mortar was replaced in Indian Army service with the 81mm L16 mortar in the late 1960s, but remained in use by the BSF. Raised following the Second Kashmir War, the BSF played a significant role in training and supporting Bangladeshi forces in 1971, and also took part in the battle of Longewala.

F3: 2nd Lieutenant Arun Khetrapal, 17 POONA HORSE

Arun Khetrapal was commissioned into 17 POONA HORSE in June 1971 and joined his regiment just before the Bangladesh War. His regiment saw action in the Shakargarh sector with 47 Infantry Brigade in the battle of Basantar. During the battle, Khetrapal's troop was part of the armour defending the bridgehead when his tank was hit by enemy fire. Undeterred, Khetrapal did not leave his tank and continued engaging the enemy. While denying the Pakistani forces the vital breakthrough, his tank received a second hit, and Khetrapal was seriously wounded. He succumbed to his injuries and his body was recovered by the Pakistanis. He was awarded the Param Vir Chakra, India's highest gallantry award, posthumously. He is wearing the black dungarees, commonly used by the armoured corps, without any headgear and carries his pistol in a holster fixed to the belt, on the right side.

G: OPERATIONS IN THE 1980S

G1: Soldier, 13 SIKH LI, Sri Lanka, 1989

This soldier wears the brushstroke-pattern uniform worn in Sri Lanka. On 12 October 1987 a platoon of 13 SIKH LI was heli-dropped at Jaffna University, along with 10 PARA (Cdo), in a bid to capture the LTTE leadership. Unfortunately, the Indian Army troops walked into an ambush due to an intelligence failure and suffered heavy casualties; 29 men of 13 SIKH LI and six paratroopers were killed in action in the most serious setback suffered by the IPKF.